



ASSEMBLE ALL THE KNOWLEDGE SCATTERED ON THE EARTH

DIDEROT PUBLISHES THE *ENCYCLOPÉDIE* (1751)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The Enlightenment

BEFORE

1517 The Reformation begins, challenging the authority of the Catholic Church.

1610 Galileo Galilei publishes *Sidereus Nuncius* (*Starry Messenger*), containing his observations of the heavens.

1687 In *Principia*, Newton outlines a concept of the universe based on natural, rationally understandable laws.

AFTER

1767 American thinker and diplomat Benjamin Franklin visits Paris, and transmits Enlightenment ideas to the US.

1791 English writer Mary Wollstonecraft adds feminism to Enlightenment ideas in the pioneering *A Vindication of the Rights of Women*.

In the mid 18th century, the French philosopher Denis Diderot invited some of his country's leading intellectuals—literary men, scientists, scholars, and philosophers to write articles for a huge “Classified Dictionary of Sciences, Arts, and Trades,” for which he was both editor-in-chief and contributor. The first volumes of his *Encyclopédie* appeared in 1751, and the full

work was completed 21 years later, made up of 17 volumes of text and another 11 volumes of illustrations.

The *Encyclopédie* was not the first large encyclopedia to be published, but it was the first to feature content by named authors, and to give close attention to the trades and crafts. Its most striking feature, however, was its critical approach to contemporary ideas and institutions: its authors were champions of scientific thought and secular values. They sought to apply reason and logic to explain the phenomena of the natural world, and humankind's existence, rather than religious or political dogma. As such, the work challenged both the Catholic Church and the French monarchy, which derived their authority from traditional ideas such as a divinely ordained, unchanging order.

A revolution in thought

The mission of the *Encyclopédie* was to catalog the collective knowledge of the Western world in the spirit of the Enlightenment. This was a multifaceted intellectual movement that took root around 1715, although its origins lay in work done by the pioneers of modern scientific and philosophical thought in the previous century. The work's multidisciplinary articles, which numbered around 72,000, distilled the ideas and theories of France's key Enlightenment thinkers—including the writers and philosophers Voltaire, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, and Montesquieu.

The articles were extremely wide-ranging, but centered on three main areas: the need to base society not on faith and the